the waves, which breaks it down in tiny pieces called microplastics. Some microplastics are also found in household products. Examples are microbeads that can be found in toothpaste, face wash and body scrubs. Microbeads are washed down in drains and end up in the soil, rivers, lakes and the ocean Microbeads are washed down in drains and end up in the soil, rivers, lakes which cause pollution.



Microplastics in the Ocean

Many birds eat plastic items and small pieces of plastic, which are covered in algae. Once in the stomach of animals, plastics cannot be digested and this decreases the amount of space for food and can lead to starvation. In 2015, plastics were found in 90% of seabirds.



We have already read that Government of Tamil Nadu has banned one-time use and throwaway plastics such as plastic carry bags, plates, straws and water pouches. This is an indication that important efforts are taking place to reduce negative consequences of plastics on the environment.



3.4.5. PLA Plastics

Can you see how much plastic litter pollutes our environment? How nice would it be if a material that had similar qualities to plastic could be biodegradable, be absorbed by the soil and give nutrients to the soil!

DO YOU KNOW?

We have seen that synthetic clothes are made from plastic. Every time we wash synthetic clothes, small fibres called microfibers escape and end up in the soil, streams, rivers and oceans.

Dangerous pollution called Persistent Organic Pollutants (POPs) floating in the ocean sticks to these small pieces of plastic making them toxic. Marine animals such as shrimp and fish often eat microplastics, confusing them for their natural source of food. The toxins build up in these animals and move up the food chain and can end up in our bodies. Microplastics can be found in the food we eat, the water we drink, and the air we breathe.

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